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# PHILOSOPHY OF ART

*a contemporary introduction*

Noël Carroll

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# 1
# Art and representation

## Part I
## Art as representation

### Art, imitation and representation

The earliest known theories of art in Western philosophy were proposed by Plato and his student Aristotle. The particular artform that most concerned them was drama. In his *Republic*, Plato presented a design for an ideal state. In the course of outlining his utopia, he argued that poets—particularly dramatists—should be outlawed. In order to justify the exclusion of dramatic poets from the ideal state, Plato had to give reasons. And the reasons Plato found had to do with what he regarded as the nature of drama. According to Plato, the essence of drama was imitation—the simulation of appearances. That is, actors in plays imitate the actions of whomever they represent. In *Medea*, the actors, for example, imitate having arguments. Plato thought that this was problematic primarily because he believed that appearances appeal to the emotions and that stirring up the emotions is socially dangerous. An emotional citizenry is an unstable citizenry, ready to be swayed by demagogues rather than by good sense.

Arguments like Plato's against poetry are still heard today when it comes to discussions of the mass media. Often we are told that TV with its seductive imagery—its seductive appearances—makes for an unthinking electorate. Carefully designed, visually arresting, political advertisements appeal to the emotions of the voters rather than to their minds. If Plato were alive today, he would probably want to censor political advertisements for the same reason that he wanted to ban dramatic poetry.

Aristotle, however, believed that Plato's case was overstated. Though he agreed that drama provokes an emotional response from audiences, he

did not think that this is all that drama does. Tragedy evokes pity and fear in spectators, but, he said, it does this for the purpose of *catharsis*—that is, for the purpose of purging the emotions. The meaning of "catharsis" is disputed among scholars. Some say that it means "clarifying" the emotions; others that it means "purifying" them; and still others that it means "evacuating" them. But, in any case, it is clear that Aristotle thought drama stimulated emotional responses for a beneficial purpose, even if we are uncertain about the precise nature of the purpose he had in mind.

Furthermore, Aristotle also thought that Plato was mistaken in presuming that drama did not address the mind of the audience. He maintained that people can learn from imitations, including dramatic imitations, and that the acquisition of knowledge from imitations is a major source of the pleasure that spectators derive from playgoing. Specifically, Aristotle thought that from dramatic poetry, viewers and readers could learn about human affairs—about how human events are likely to turn out once certain forces are put in motion (for example, once a powerful and resourceful woman like Medea is thrown over for her younger rival). Thus, Aristotle argues implicitly that there is enough good in drama for us to desist from implementing Plato's recommendation. Dramatic poets can remain in the righteous city.

Though Plato and Aristotle disagree in their diagnosis of the effects of dramatic poetry, they nevertheless agree on its nature. Both take poetry to be involved essentially in the imitation of action. Dramatic poetry represents human affairs by simulating human events on stage. Plato and Aristotle also talk about painting in their discussions of poetry, and, again, both agree that painting is essentially a matter of imitation—of verisimilitude. Plato describes painting as analogous to pointing a mirror toward things—an idea Shakespeare extends to drama when Hamlet instructs the players to hold a mirror up to nature.

What painters try to do, on the Platonic-Aristotelian view, is to reproduce the appearances of things—to copy them—not only people, but objects and events. Their view of painting parallels the view of their culture. Popular Greek stories of the painter Zeuxis, for instance, applaud him because he was able to draw pictures of grapes of such surpassing likeness that birds tried to eat them.

Since Plato and Aristotle primarily thought of dance and music as accompaniments to dramatic (or religious) spectacles, or poetic recitals, they thought of these artforms as subservient to the purposes of representation. They did not regard them so much as separate artforms, but as supplements or adjuncts of drama. They were parts of drama, and, as such, they were supposed to serve the imitative purposes of drama. Thus, along with drama and painting, Plato and Aristotle thought of music and dance as primarily imitative or representational arts.

When the Greeks used their word for "art," they had a broader conception in mind than we do today. For them, an art was any practice that required skill. Medicine and soldiering were arts on this conception. Thus, Plato and Aristotle would not have defined the arts, in their sense, as solely involved in imitation. However, it is clear that when they talk of what we call the *arts*—things like poetry, drama, painting, sculpture, dance and music—Plato and Aristotle thought that these shared a common feature: they were all involved in imitation.

Undoubtedly they did not think that these activities were the only ones that involved imitation; Aristotle talks about the way in which children imitate their elders. But imitation, for Plato and Aristotle, was at least a *necessary condition* for the kinds of practices we call art. That is, being an imitation—of a person, place, object, action or event—is a general feature that anything categorized as an artwork (in our sense) must possess. This is the theory of art that we find presupposed in the writings of Plato and Aristotle. We may state it thus:

x is an artwork only if it is an imitation.

In this formulation, the phrase "only if" signals that imitation is a necessary condition for art status. If a candidate for art status lacks the property of being an imitation of something, then it is not an artwork. For Plato and Aristotle, to be an artwork requires that the piece in question be an imitation of something. Nothing is an artwork, unless it is an imitation.

Today, after almost a century of abstract painting, this theory seems obviously false. Certain well-known paintings by Mark Rothko and Yves Klein do not imitate anything—they are pure fields of color—and yet they are considered major works of twentieth-century art. Thus, the theory that art is imitation appears to us to fail as a general theory of art, since it fails to be fully comprehensive. Too much of what we know to be art does not meet the alleged necessary requirement that anything that is art be imitative.

Art history has shown us that the theory of art associated with Plato and Aristotle is too exclusive; it confronts too many exceptions; it fails to count as art everything that we regard as belonging to the category of art. Walk through almost any art museum today, and you should be able to find some counterexamples to this theory.

Yet, in deference to Plato and Aristotle, we should also add that their theory was not as obviously false to them as it is to us, since the primary examples of art in their day were imitative. When they went to the theater, or when they went to the unveiling of a new sculpture, what they saw were imitations of heroes and gods and persons and actions—pieces

of stones that looked like men, dancers that mimed human action, and plays that re-enacted important mythological events—like the destruction of the House of Atreus. Thus, given the data that history had dealt them, the theory of art that Plato and Aristotle presupposed was fairly well motivated by what was available to them. It is only through the benefit of hindsight that we can see how far off they were.

So, in their own time, the imitative (mimetic) theory of art advanced by Plato and Aristotle had some initial plausibility. It coincided with the dominant examples of Greek art and it also informed readers about what to look for and to appreciate in the art of their contemporaries, namely its verisimilitude. That is, the theory of Plato and Aristotle had a pretty good fit with the data; it did a reasonable job of at least picking out what was important—or, perhaps, most important—in Greek artistic practices.

Due to the initial success of this theory, it was repeated in the Western tradition for centuries. The theory became especially important in the eighteenth century, since it was at that time that theorists began to codify our modern system of the fine arts.

What is meant by a "system of the fine arts?" Here, what we have in mind is a way of grouping certain practices—like painting and poetry—into a category distinct from other practices—like astronomy and chemistry. Prior to the eighteenth century, practices were grouped in a number of different ways. Music and mathematics, for example, might be placed in the same category. However, in the eighteenth century, a certain way of grouping various practices became canonical. Painting, poetry, dance, music, drama and sculpture came to be regarded as the fine arts—the arts with a capital A. These are the practices, with the later addition of a few others, like film, that nowadays we expect to be listed in the section of college bulletins devoted to the arts programs; and these are the kinds of things we expect to find represented at art centers. We do not expect to find scale models of space stations there.

Today this way of grouping the arts seems natural to us. But it was not always so. It is not until the eighteenth century that this way of classifying the relevant activities became more or less fixed. A particularly important text in bringing this about was *The Fine Arts Reduced to a Single Principle,* which was written by the Frenchman Charles Batteux in 1747. Notice that the title of this book indicates that the practices in the group called the fine arts are not assembled helter-skelter; they are not thrown together under the same title arbitrarily. Rather, it is said that there is a *single principle* to which all the pertinent activities can be reduced. And what is that principle? Imitation.

Batteux wrote, "We will define painting, sculpture and dance as the imitation of beautiful nature conveyed through colors, through relief and through attitudes. And music and poetry are the imitation of beautiful

nature conveyed through sounds, or through measured discourse." For Batteux, membership in the system of the fine arts required that a practice meet a certain necessary condition, namely that it be imitative. In this, Batteux articulated a presupposition widely upheld in the eighteenth century—that art, as we call it, is to be defined essentially in terms of the Platonic-Aristotelian notion of imitation.

At first, it may seem strange to you that this characterization could ever have taken hold. You may wonder, for example, how music could have been regarded as an imitative art. Here, theorists argued not only that music could imitate beautiful sounds in nature—like birdsongs and thunder—but, more importantly, that it could imitate the human voice, for example, in spirited conversation.

Similarly, though much dance, such as social dance, does not appear imitative, eighteenth-century theorists, essentially reformers, advocated that theatrical dancing—dance as art—become imitative, following Aristotle's philosophy of drama, in order to join the modern system of the arts; the result was the *ballet d'action*, which dominated the dance stage of the nineteenth century. Moreover, the commitment to imitation also encouraged serious painters (painters dedicated to making art with a capital A) to continue their pursuit of greater and greater feats of realism (the attempt to approximate the perceptual appearance of things as closely as possible).

Thus, for several reasons, the authority of the imitation theory of art persisted well into the nineteenth century. A proponent of the theory could still claim that the imitation theory of art did a good job of describing existing art properly so called, since the vast majority of the most prominent examples of painting, drama, opera, dance, sculpture and so on were imitative (if only, in some cases, because practitioners aspired to meet the criterion necessary for cherished membership of the system of the fine arts). And, as well, there were also theories—such as the view that music imitates the human voice—that enabled apparent counterexamples to be explained away. Indeed, the influence of the imitation theory of art can still be found in the twentieth century: until only a generation ago, one could hear people saying of an abstract painting that it isn't art because it doesn't look like anything. And even today, some people will say that a certain film is not art because it lacks a story—that is, because it is not an imitation of action.

Of course, views like this are presently regarded as philistine—the opinion of people uninformed about art and, unfortunately, unashamed by displaying their ignorance. But that ignorance does not come from nowhere. It is a residue of the imitation theory of art, which theory, until the nineteenth century had, as we have indicated, some empirical credibility. Several things, however, have happened since then to undermine the theory decisively.

By the late nineteenth century and early twentieth century, visual art clearly begins to deviate from the aim of imitating nature. Visual art departs from the aim of copying how things look; photography could do that. German expressionist painters left off trying to capture exactly the look of things and, instead, distorted them for expressive effects. Cubists, action painters, and minimalists diverged from nature even further until finally making paintings whose referents, if any, were completely unrecognizable became a dominant tradition. Consider, for example, the work of Josef Albers, whose vocabulary comprises squares of color.

These examples of modern art refuted the imitation theory of art as a general philosophical conjecture, since they show that something can be a work of art that is not an imitation. Moreover, these examples also lead us to take another look at the tradition of visual art. The imitation theory claims that all art is imitative. Art in the twentieth century shows that that theory is false. But these counterexamples also encourage us to take a second look at art history and to ask whether the imitation theory was ever accurate. Contemplating the examples of twentieth-century art, I think we are inclined to realize that the imitation theory never got it quite right. Minimalist art, for instance, reminds us that there was always visual art of pure visual design, from carpets and pottery to illuminated texts and Islamic wall patterns. The history of pure visual decoration is as longstanding as the history of figuration.

Similarly, once alerted to the oversights of the imitation theory with respect to visual art, we need to reconsider the case of music. Is music really imitative? In times gone by, when music served primarily the function of accompanying words—in opera and religious chant, for example— one might have been tempted to assimilate music to the imitative arts. But with the triumph of symphonic music—pure orchestral music—in the early nineteenth century, the generalization that all music is representational was no longer tenable, if it ever was, since there was nonvocal music—marches and dance accompaniments—prior to the Romantic symphony. Likewise, modern drama has not only deviated from the imitation of action—in Futurist plays like Giacomo Balla's T*o Understand Weeping* —giving rise to the dreamlike spectacles of Robert Wilson, but it also alerts us to the history of nonimitative performance, including many rituals and processions. And postmodern dance, with its emphasis on the perception of movement for its own sake, reminds us that much dance, including ballet *divertissements,* does not imitate, but rather explores the possibilities of human performance.

Furthermore, once we begin to poke holes in the imitation theory of art, we realize that it never really adequately characterized literature. Since Plato and Aristotle thought of literature in terms of dramatic poetry, it is easy to see why they thought it was imitative—it involved

actors imitating the speech of characters. Even lyric poetry spoken aloud can be characterized this way. But once we start to think of literature in terms of novels and short stories, the idea that it is imitative, where imitation involves copying or simulating appearances, becomes strained. For novels are made up of words, and words don't look like their referents. The words that describe Holden in *The Catcher in the Rye* do not perceptually simulate anyone.

In order to deal with this problem, and others, the friend of the Platonic-Aristotelian theory may leave off talking in terms of imitation in favor of representation. By representation, here, is meant something that is intended to stand for something else and that is recognized by audiences as such. A portrait, for example, is intended to stand for whomever it is a portrait of, and viewers recognize it as such. This, of course, is an example of imitation, and imitation is a subcategory of representation. However, the notion of representation is broader, since something can also stand for something else without looking like it. For example, the *fleur-de-lys* can stand for the royal house of Bourbon without resembling it.

Moreover, by speaking of representation rather than imitation, conceived literally, the Platonic-Aristotelian theorist can deal with the problem of literature, since the description of the Battle of Borodino in *War and Peace* represents it without literally copying it. Likewise, many twentieth-century abstractions in visual art, like the paintings of Mondrian, represent something—such as ultimate reality—without rendering its literal appearance.

Reconstruing the imitation theory of art as the representational theory of art yields a position of greater generality, since the concept of representation is broader than the concept of imitation. But even with this additional breadth, the representational theory of art remains unsalvageable, since much art is not representational.

Stated formulaically, x represents y (where y ranges over a domain comprised of objects, persons, events and actions) if and only if (1) a sender intends x (e.g., a picture) to stand for y (e.g., a haystack) and (2) the audience realizes that x is intended to stand for y.

But there are many works of art that are not representations in this sense. Consider architecture: many of the finest buildings in history are not intended to stand for something. The cathedral of St. Peter in Rome does not stand for a house of God; it is a house of God. Similarly the Capitol Building in Washington, D.C. does not stand for the legislature; it houses the legislature. The representational theory of art may provide the means for incorporating much literature under the rubric of art, but it still leaves much architecture of the sort we are apt to regard as art outside the category. Thus, the representational theory of art, like the imitation theory of art, is too exclusive to serve as a general theory of art.

Of course, the problem with the representational theory of art is not simply that it excludes too much architecture from the category of art. It also excludes important and obvious examples of art from every other artistic genre as well. Some orchestral music may be representational, but most is not. Some abstract paintings are essentially formal exercises representing nothing, and there are even songs and poems like this. And there are also abstract films, videos, photographs, dances and even theater pieces (performance art) that stand for nothing, but are presented as occasions for concentrated perceptual experiences. These examples are primarily modern in origin. But the representational theory of art is not only refuted by modern examples. For as we have already indicated, decorative art throughout the ages provides an ample field of counterexamples—works based in the pleasing play of forms, representing nothing.

## The neo-representational theory of art

Neither the imitation theory of art nor the broader representational theory of art appears successful. Neither gives us a general theory of art; neither designates a necessary property of all artworks. However, there is a recent variation on the representational theory of art which seems, at least at first blush, less susceptible to counterexamples than its predecessors. We can call this variation the neo-representational theory of art, though, it must be admitted, that this is a bit of a misnomer, since the theory does not claim that in order to be an artwork a candidate must represent something in the sense stipulated above. The neo-representational theory makes a weaker claim, namely that in order to count as a work of art, the candidate must be about something (i.e., it must have a subject, about which it makes some comment). Moreover, that about which the artwork expresses something may be the artwork itself or art in general.

Stated briefly, the theory maintains that:

> x is an artwork only if it is about something.

This theory can be expanded by being more explicit about what is involved in being "about something."

> x is an artwork only if x has a subject about which it makes some comment (about which it says something, or expresses some observation).

This notion might also be stated by alleging that in order to count as art, a candidate must have some semantic content. Indeed, it is in virtue of the requirement that all artworks possess semantic content that we call this theory neo-representationalism, since the concept of semantics and that of representation are intimately connected.

According to the neo-representational theory of art, anything that is a work of art necessarily possesses the property of aboutness—it has semantic content; it has a subject about which it expresses something. *King Lear,* for example, has a subject, governance, about which it says something: a house divided shall not stand. Likewise, Picasso's *Guernica* is about something, aerial bombardment, about which it expresses horror.

Perhaps the easiest way to see what is attractive about neorepresentationalism is to note how it handles some difficult cases of modern art. One genre of modern art is the readymade or the found object. Marcel Duchamp is a name often associated with this genre. Two of his more notorious works are *Fountain* and *In Advance of a Broken Arm*. The former is an ordinary urinal; the latter is a snow shovel. These are called readymades or found objects because they came readymade off the factory assembly line; Duchamp did not make them—he, so to speak, found them.

Though today there may still be some people who deny that these readymades are artworks, practicing artists, critics and art historians treat these works as central moments in twentieth-century art. Thus, there is at least a *prima facie* case for regarding them as artworks. But, assuming that they are artworks, a puzzle arises. If *fountain* and *In Advance of a Broken Arm* are artworks, why aren't things that look just like them—ordinary urinals and snow shovels from the same factories—artworks too?

Duchamp's readymades are perceptually indiscernible from their ordinary, real-world counterparts. Yet we classify Duchamp's artworks and their ordinary, perceptually indiscernible, real-world counterparts in terms of radically different categories, and this has important consequences. We do not stand before ordinary urinals contemplating their meaning, nor do we store the snow shovels in our garage with velvet ropes around them to insure that visitors maintain a proper distance from them. Why not? Why do we treat things that look exactly the same so differently?

Because Duchamp's readymades are artworks, whereas ordinary urinals and snow shovels are not. But what property or properties do Duchamp's readymades possess that their indiscernible counterparts lack? Here, the neo-representationalist advances the tantalizing hypothesis that Duchamp's readymades possess aboutness, whereas their ordinary, perceptually indiscernible, real-world counterparts do not.

This argument is what is called an hypothesis to the best explanation— that is, neo-representationalism offers the best explanation of why we make the awesome categorical distinction between Duchamp's readymades and ordinary real things (the former counting as art; the latter not); and inasmuch as neo-representationalism is the best explanation, we have good inductive grounds for accepting it. By being the best explanation, neo-representationalism recommends itself to us.

But what does it mean to say that the readymades possess aboutness? That they have a subject about which they say something. For example, art historians often maintain that *Fountain* and *In Advance of a Broken Arm* are about art—about the nature of art—about which they insinuate that artworks need not be literally created or sculpted by the labor of the artist (the artist need not literally be an artificer). This view contrasts with more sanctimonious views of art which regard the artwork as virtually a relic or spiritual imprint of the genius-artist. Or, it might be said, Duchamp makes the theoretical point that the essence of art is not manual labor or craft. In addition, *Fountain* might be "read" as a parody of scuplture—after all, like the monumental fountains that grace great cities, it is a fashioned stone artifact replete with running water.

In short, Duchamp's readymades warrant interpretations. It makes sense to ask what they are about. The sorts of interpretations rehearsed in the preceding paragraph answer that question. On the other hand, it does not make sense to ask what ordinary urinals and snow shovels are about. Ordinary urinals and snow shovels are not about anything; they have no semantic content; they are mute—meaningless. If you stand in your driveway after a blizzard, looking at your snow shovel and asking after its meaning, people will suppose you are either trying to avoid clearing off the snow or that you are a candidate for institutionalization. And if you stand in the men's restroom contemplating what the urinals express, you'll probably get arrested.

Our behavior, then, confronting readymades versus their indiscernible real-world counterparts is radically different. With readymades we presume that it is correct and appropriate to interpret them—we presume that they are about something and that an appropriate response to them is to determine what they have to "say" or what they imply concerning whatever they are about. This is not the appropriate response to ordinary urinals and shovels. Why not? Because the latter are not artworks and, therefore, are not about anything.

The neo-representational theory of art does a good job of explaining the difference between readymades and their perceptually indiscernible, real-world counterparts. Thus, it solves an important contemporary problem. But it is also proposed as a general theory of art—aboutness is not simply a necessary property of readymades, but of all art. So the

question is: how generalizable is aboutness? Is it a property of all artworks?

Neo-representationalism maintains that aboutness or semantic content is a necessary condition of all artworks. Clearly, semantic content is not a feature of only artworks. Many other sorts of things—from sermons to advertisements to physics articles—have a subject about which they say something. So aboutness is not the unique mark of only artworks. But is it, nevertheless, a property that anything that is an artwork must possess (even if other things possess it as well)?

One way to argue for this conclusion is to begin with the premise that all artworks require interpretations. When one reads art criticism or art history books, one is struck by the fact that they are full of interpretations. It is natural to presume that all artworks are open to interpretation, since that is what people who are experts about art always seem to do with artworks—they interpret them. But if anything calls for an interpretation, then surely it must be about something—it must say something, have a meaning or possess semantic content.

This much seems built into the concept or the definition of an interpretation—that is, it is a necessary condition of interpretation that the object of interpretation have a subject about which it makes some comment. An interpretation is just the specification of that content. Anything that truly warrants an interpretation must be about something—otherwise it would not require an interpretation. Why else would it require an interpretation, unless it were about something? Thus, if artworks require interpretations, then they must be about something. This follows from what it is to be an interpretation.

Stated formally, this argument maintains that:

1 All artworks require interpretations.
2 If anything requires an interpretation, then it must be about something.
3 Therefore, all artworks are about something.

This is a strong argument in favor of neo-representationalism. Moreover, it should be clear that neo-representationalism is superior to the representational theory of art, since it is a broader theory. The central defining property of art that it proposes—being about something—is more comprehensive than the one advanced by the representational theory— standing for something else. For if x stands for y, x is about something, but there are more ways for x to be about something than standing for it. The film *Diary of a Country Priest* is about divine grace, but it doesn't stand for or represent divine grace. Thus, insofar as aboutness is broader than strict representation, neo-representationalism

may not be as fatally narrow as the other theories we have examined so far.

The argument for neo-representationalism is logically valid, but that does not mean that its conclusion is true. The conclusion of a logically valid argument is only guaranteed to be true if the premises of the argument are true. So the question before us is whether the preceding premises are true. The second premise rests on or follows from the concept or definition of interpretation. It seems credible. So is the first premise of the argument—that all artworks require interpretations—acceptable?

One reason to dispute it originates in the practice of contemporary artists. Many contemporary artists aspire to create works of art that are designed to defy interpretation or to be utterly meaningless. Sometimes artists claim to do this in order to "deconstruct" the distinction between artworks and real things. This might be one way to view certain readymades—as examples of the supposed fact that ultimately there is no genuine difference between artworks and real things.

However, ironically, the neo-representationalist can argue that attempts along these lines really confirm the thesis of neo-representationalism. Why? Because artworks that are advanced to exemplify the thesis that artworks are ultimately real things are, in fact, not at all like real things, since such artworks have semantic content. They are about something— namely the nature of artworks—about which they have something to say: that artworks are actually real things. An artist cannot make an artwork whose point is that artworks are real things by simply making a real thing, since by saying something (by making a point) the piece is already more than a mute, meaningless real thing—because it has aboutness and warrants an interpretation.

Real things don't exemplify the property of real-thingness, though they possess it; something designed to exemplify real-thingness in order to make a theoretical point obviously has semantic content, semantic content of the sort that art critics will explicate by pointing to the artist's commitment to showing that artworks are ultimately real things. Even if the theoretical point that the artwork is intended to communicate is false, nevertheless in attempting to communicate a theoretical point, the work in question is necessarily about something. Thus, neo-representationalism is not challenged by avant-garde artworks that are "against interpretation," since by attempting to resist interpretation for the sake of disclosing the true nature of art, they, instead, mandate interpretation. Consequently, and paradoxically enough, modern artworks predicated on refuting neorepresentationalism actually count in its favor.

Unlike the imitation theory of art and the representational theory of art, neo-representationalism does a nice job of handling cases of modern art. Much modern art is about the nature of art; thus it will satisfy the

requirement of aboutness. Of course, not all modern art concerns the nature of art. Some modern art is concerned with metaphysical, political, spiritual or psychological matters. But neo-representationalism will have no problem with these works either, since they are all about something, even in cases where the artworks are abstract or nonfigurative.

Moreover, neo-representationalism looks like it can deal with a number of the other counterexamples that beset the representational theory of art. Much music and architecture that does not stand for anything nevertheless possesses expressive properties. The Pentagon, for example, expresses strength and substance, while some pure orchestral music strikes us as joyous. Might we not say that what these examples are about—what they mean, what comprises their semantic content—is their expressive content: strength, on the one hand, and joyousness, on the other?

And lastly, with respect to decorative art, the neo-representationalist will point out that many of the seemingly abstract decorations on artworks from remote cultures are not at all truly meaningless, but, when understood in their correct historical context, they will be seen to have religious or ritual significance. Thus even art that is allegedly merely decorative generally has aboutness.

Neo-representationalism, then, is a powerful theory. It has the resources to cover a lot of the ground that is inhospitable to the imitation and representation theories of art. It is far less exclusive than either of those views and this bodes well on its behalf. It is a more encompassing theory than the other theories in this family of representational theories, but is it encompassing enough? There are several reasons to think that it is not.

First, it is not certain that the way in which the neo-representationalist deals with some of our earlier counterexamples is really convincing. Confronted by certain cases of pure orchestral music and non-representational architecture, the neo-representationalist notes that they may possess expressive properties and that this is what such works are about. But this seems questionable. Suppose a piece of pure orchestral music is sad. Is this really what it is about? Does it truly have a subject, sadness, about which it expresses something? Does the possession of a property amount to being about the property?

It seems strained to say so. It possesses the property, but what does it say about it? If a painting possesses the property redness, mere possession of the property hardly counts as being about redness. Though you may possess red hair, you are not "about" having red hair. Being about a property surely requires more than mere possession of the property. So, the neo-representationalist's solution for dealing with the hard cases of much pure orchestral music and nonrepresentational architecture is not actually successful.

Another way of getting at this objection is to note that when we say that a piece of music is sad, we are not really interpreting it in any robust sense of the word. Reporting that the music is sad is more a matter of describing a perceptible property of the work. In pertinent respects, it is akin to saying that the work has a fast tempo. Once again, that a work possesses a fast tempo is not enough to say it is about "having a fast tempo"; that would require some further level of articulation from the work that calls attention to, makes reference to, and/or implies some comment or point about its having a fast tempo. Because mere possession of a fast tempo does not involve these things, no interpretation is called for in a case like this to identify the music's subject about which it expresses something. We need not interpret the music in either the case of its possession of a fast tempo or its sadness, since there is nothing that the music is about in the neo-representationalist's sense. But if certain pieces of pure orchestral music and nonrepresentational architecture, even though they possess expressive properties, are not about these properties and require no interpretation, then they become, in effect, counterexamples to neorepresentationalism.

If the neo-representationalist response to the preceding types of hard cases was too hasty, it may be that the neo-representationalist's method of dealing with decorative art is also problematic. The neo-representationalist makes the good point that often what appears to us as mere decoration occurs in cultural contexts where it has symbolic, perhaps religious or ritual, significance and, therefore, aboutness. But the question is whether all cases of decorative art can be handled in this manner. Isn't there some decorative art that is simply a matter of stimulating pleasure by its design or its appearance? This is often what we mean when we describe something as beautiful—that we find a pattern arresting and pleasing.

Surely some artworks are simply beautiful in this sense. They are, so to say, "beneath interpretation." They do not require interpretation. They work their magic, or, at least, they are intended to do so, solely in virtue of the perceptual impact they make on us. They are not about beauty; they are beautiful. They express nothing about beauty in general, nor about the particular beauty that they possess. Perhaps some decorative art does more than this; perhaps some of it has latent religious significance. But, equally, much decorative art—including aural as well as visual art—addresses us only on the perceptual level—by being only beautiful or intriguing—and it is valued for that very reason. This sort of art is not really about anything. It is stimulating in a pleasing way, while not being about stimulation. But if we grant that there is such art, as I think we must, then there is art that is not about anything.

Cases like this—of pure decoration—are not isolated exceptions. There is a great deal of art of this sort. Moreover, there is a great deal of architecture and music that, though it may possess expressive properties—and for that

matter beauty—is not about anything. Thus, there is a great deal of art that the neo-representational theory fails to accommodate. Neo-representationalism is more comprehensive than the imitation theory and the representational theory of art, but it is still nowhere near comprehensiveenough. Thus, it would appear that none of the views in this family of theories is satisfactory as a general philosophical theory of all art.

# Part II
# What is representation?

## Pictorial representation

So far we have seen that representation-type theories of art are inadequate. Neither the imitation theory, the representational theory nor the neorepresentational theory succeed in discovering a general property that all works, in order to count as artworks, must possess. For some art is nonrepresentational—some art imitates nothing, stands for nothing, and is about nothing. And yet, even though much art is not representational, much other art is. Consequently, despite the fact that much art is not representational—thereby falsifying representational theories of art—since much other art is representational, we still need a theory of representation, a theory that explicates that which the concept of representation comprises.

Visual art is the art that most people are disposed to have in mind first when we speak of representation and/or imitation. So it is a useful place to start our discussions of representation.

Clearly, much visual art is representational. Representation is so important to the history of visual art that there have been moments in bygone eras when visual art was thought of primarily in terms of pictures. And even today much visual art is representational. Typically, the vast majority of photographs, movies, videos and TV programs that surround us are representations, indeed, representations that many might say proceed by way of imitation. Consequently, we may initiate our discussion of the concept of representation in art by focussing on visual or pictorial representation which we intend to encompass such things as: frescoes of the Sun god from Afghanistan, Wunggadinda's